STAAR Bootcamp: staarvival

🌿 STAAR-vival: Escape the Test — Quick-Start Overview

Welcome, Explorer!

You've downloaded **STAAR-vival** — a survival/adventure-themed STAAR prep week where students journey through 5 different terrains, building skills and earning survival badges along the way. By Friday, they've "survived" the wilderness and are ready to conquer the STAAR.

📦 What's in This Package

File	What It Is
LESSON-PLANS.md	5-day survival journey lesson plans with teacher scripts
ACTIVITIES.md	12 adventure-themed activities including Tribal Council review game
DECORATIONS.md	Jungle vines, base camp signs, classroom explorer setup
STUDENT-MATERIALS.md	Explorer journals, survival badges, maps, certificates
PARENT-LETTER.md	Family communication in English and Spanish

🗺️ The Theme at a Glance

- **Setting:** Wilderness survival expedition

- **Students are:** Explorers on a 5-day journey
- **Teacher is:** Lead Explorer / Trail Guide
- **Each day is:** A new terrain to survive
- **Completing work earns:** Survival Badges
- **The week builds to:** Reaching the Summit (STAAR mastery)
- **Hallway becomes:** A jungle/wilderness trail
- **Classroom becomes:** Base Camp

📅 Week Overview

Day	Terrain	Focus
Monday	🌴 **Jungle**	Reading/ELA — navigating dense text
Tuesday	🏜️ **Desert**	Math — precision and resourcefulness
Wednesday	⛰️ **Mountains**	Science & Social Studies — climbing to new knowledge
Thursday	🌊 **Ocean**	Mixed review — deep dive, navigating currents
Friday	⛰️ **Summit**	Test strategies, celebration — you made it to the top!

⏰ How to Run This Week

2 Weeks Before

- [ ] Read LESSON-PLANS.md
- [ ] Buy supplies (DECORATIONS.md)
- [ ] Print student materials (STUDENT-MATERIALS.md)

- [ ] Send parent letter

Weekend Before

- [ ] Set up hallway decorations (jungle vines, base camp signs)
- [ ] Set up classroom as Base Camp
- [ ] Organize daily "survival kits" (supply packets)

Each Morning

1. Play nature/adventure sounds as students enter
2. Deliver the **Trail Briefing** (see teacher scripts)
3. Distribute daily survival challenge packet
4. Run themed activities
5. Award **Survival Badges** at end of day
6. Update the **Journey Map** — mark the day's terrain as conquered

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💡 Pro Tips

1. **Wear khaki or a safari hat.** The sillier you go, the more they love it.
2. **Nature sounds are free.** YouTube has hours of jungle/ocean/mountain ambiance. Play it softly during independent work.
3. **The journey map is KEY.** Students love seeing visual progress. Mark each terrain as completed.
4. **Tribal Council is the highlight.** Save it for the end of each day — it's the reward.
5. **Survival kits = pencil pouches.** Put 2 pencils, an eraser, and a small snack in a ziplock. Label "Survival Kit." Kids go wild.

The wilderness awaits, Explorer. Lead your team to the summit! ⛰️

🌿 STAAR-vival: Escape the Test — 5-Day

Lesson Plans

> ***Trail Guide's Handbook — Navigate the week terrain by terrain.***

Daily Schedule Template

Time Block	Duration	Activity
Trail Briefing	10 min	Theme intro, daily terrain overview, motivation
Survival Training 1	45 min	Core skill review / guided practice
Rest Stop	5 min	Brain break
Survival Training 2	40 min	Practice / application
Tribal Council	10 min	End-of-day review game + badge ceremony

🌴 MONDAY — Jungle Terrain

Theme: "The jungle is dense and full of surprises. Reading is like navigating a jungle — you have to push through the thick text to find what you need."

Focus: Reading/ELA

Trail Briefing (10 min)

Teacher Script: > "Explorers! Welcome to STAAR-vival. I'm your Lead Explorer, and this week we're going on the adventure of a lifetime. We'll cross five terrains — jungle, desert, mountains, ocean, and finally the summit. Each terrain will test different survival

skills. Today: the JUNGLE. The jungle is dense, confusing, full of hidden dangers — just like a tough reading passage. But a trained explorer knows how to navigate. They look for paths, read the signs, and find their way through. Today, we learn to navigate the jungle of text. Grab your survival kits — let's move out!"

Hand out: Explorer Journals, Survival Badge Cards, Survival Kits (pencil pouches)

Survival Training 1 (45 min)

Reading/ELA Focus: 1. **(10 min) "Trail Markers" Warm-Up** — 5 quick questions on whiteboards. "Trail markers help you find your way. Key words in questions are YOUR trail markers." 2. **(20 min) "Machete Through the Text"** — Teacher models close reading/annotation of a dense STAAR passage. "We're cutting through the jungle. Every time I find an important detail, I mark the trail." Demonstrate highlighting, margin notes, underlining key evidence. 3. **(15 min) "Buddy System"** — Partners read a passage together. One reads aloud (slowly, like hiking through brush), the other marks trail markers (key details). Discuss and answer 3-4 questions together.

Rest Stop (5 min)

- "Animal Sounds" brain break — teacher calls an animal, students make the sound and a movement (monkey = ooh-ooh + arm swings, snake = hisssss + slither). Silly. Effective.

Survival Training 2 (40 min)

"Jungle Survival Challenge" Packet - STAAR-format reading passages with questions - Themed: "You found this message carved into a tree. Read it carefully…" - Early finishers: "Hidden Treasure" bonus challenge

Differentiation: - **Struggling:** "Trail Guide" version — shorter passages, vocabulary pre-taught, guided annotation marks provided - **Advanced:** "Uncharted Territory" — complex texts with analytical questions - **ELL:** Visual vocabulary cards, bilingual key terms

Tribal Council (10 min)

- Quick review game: Teacher reads a question, students vote (thumbs up/down for answer choices A-D). Discuss the correct "verdict."
- Award **Jungle Survival Badges** 🌴
- Update Journey Map: Jungle = CONQUERED

🏜️ TUESDAY — Desert Terrain

Theme: "The desert is harsh and unforgiving. Resources are scarce. Every drop of water counts — just like every step in a math problem counts."

Focus: Mathematics

Trail Briefing (10 min)

Teacher Script: > "Explorers, we survived the jungle! Today we enter the DESERT. In the desert, you can't waste anything. Every resource matters. Math is like desert survival — every step in your work matters. Skip a step, and you're lost. Show ALL your work today. Conserve your energy. Be precise. The desert rewards the careful and punishes the careless. Let's cross this desert!"

Survival Training 1 (45 min)

Math Focus: 1. **(10 min) "Water Rationing" Warm-Up** — 5 computation problems. "Each correct answer = one water bottle for your team. Get them wrong, and you're dehydrated!" 2. **(20 min) "Map & Compass" Guided Practice** — Teacher models multi-step word problems as navigation challenges. "We need to calculate the distance to the next oasis…" Show every step. Emphasize: "In the desert, skipping steps = getting lost." 3. **(15 min) "Resource Sharing"** — Partners work through 6 problems. Each partner solves 3 independently, then they check each other's work. "Your buddy's life depends on your accuracy!"

Rest Stop (5 min)

- "Mirage or Real?" — Teacher shows 5 quick math statements. Students decide: true (real) or false (mirage). Stand up for real, sit for mirage.

Survival Training 2 (40 min)

"Desert Survival Challenge" Packet - STAAR-format math problems - Themed intro: "You need to calculate your way across the desert. One wrong answer and you veer off course."

Differentiation: - **Struggling:** Reference sheet, worked examples, fewer problems - **Advanced:** "Scorching Challenge" — complex multi-step problems - **ELL:** Simplified word problem language, math vocabulary visuals

Tribal Council (10 min)

- "Oasis or Mirage?" — Teacher presents 3 worked-out problems. Some have errors hidden in them. Students vote on whether each is correct (oasis) or has an error (mirage). Find the errors together.
- Award **Desert Survival Badges** 🏜️
- Journey Map update: Desert = CONQUERED

⛰️ WEDNESDAY — Mountain Terrain

Theme: "Mountains are the ultimate challenge. You can see the summit, but the climb is steep. Science and social studies are our mountains to climb."

Focus: Science & Social Studies (or continued ELA/Math review)

Trail Briefing (10 min)

Teacher Script: > "We've cleared the jungle and crossed the desert. Now we face the MOUNTAINS. The climb is steep, but the view from the top? Incredible. Today we tackle science and social studies — the peaks of knowledge. Every fact you learn, every concept you master, gets you one step closer to the summit. And remember — we climb together. No explorer left behind!"

Survival Training 1 (45 min)

Science Review: 1. **(10 min) "Base Camp Check"** — 5 rapid-fire science questions on whiteboards 2. **(20 min) "Mountain Stations"** — 4-5 stations around the room, each a different "elevation" (difficulty) and science topic. Students rotate in groups (5 min each). Each station has a terrain flavor: "Elevation 1000ft: Matter & Energy," "Elevation 3000ft: Force & Motion," etc. 3. **(15 min) "Trail Journal"** — Students write in Explorer Journals: draw a compass rose with 4 science topics on each point, add key facts along each direction.

Rest Stop (5 min)

- "Mountain Goat Balance" — Students stand on one foot for 30 seconds. Switch. Silly balance challenge. "Mountain goats never fall!"

Survival Training 2 (40 min)

Social Studies + Mixed Review: 1. **(15 min) "History Hike" Timeline** — Collaborative timeline activity (same as STAAR Command but themed as a mountain trail — events placed at increasing "elevations") 2. **(25 min) "Mountain Challenge" Packet** — Mixed science/social studies STAAR questions

Tribal Council (10 min)

- **Full Tribal Council Game:** Teams of 4-5. Teacher reads a question with 4 answer choices. Each team discusses (1 min), then "votes" by holding up A/B/C/D cards. Teams that voted correctly survive. Teams that voted wrong are "on the chopping block" — they must answer a bonus question to stay in the game. Last team standing wins.
- Award **Mountain Survival Badges** ⛰️
- Journey Map: Mountains = CONQUERED
- Midweek treat! 🎉

🌊 THURSDAY — Ocean Terrain

Theme: "The ocean is vast and deep. Today we take a deep dive — full STAAR review, navigating the currents of a mixed test."

Focus: Mixed STAAR-format practice (all subjects)

Trail Briefing (10 min)

Teacher Script: > "Explorers. Jungle, desert, mountains — all conquered. Now we face the OCEAN. The ocean is unpredictable. Currents can pull you off course. Waves can knock you down. But if you stay calm and use your skills, you'll swim right through. Today is our deep dive — a full practice crossing all subjects. Treat it like the real STAAR. Stay focused. Breathe. Navigate the currents."

Survival Training 1 (45 min)

"Deep Dive Simulation" - Mini STAAR-format practice test (20-30 mixed questions) - Test-like conditions: silent, independent, timed - "You're swimming across the ocean. Every correct answer is a stroke closer to shore."

Rest Stop (5 min)

- Deep breathing exercise: "When you're swimming and you get tired, you float. Close your eyes. Breathe. Float."

Survival Training 2 (40 min)

"Surfacing" Analysis & Review 1. **(15 min)** Review answers together 2. **(10 min)** Students fill out self-assessment: strengths, weak areas, strategy adjustments 3. **(15 min)** Small group "rescue teams" — students grouped by need, targeted review

Tribal Council (10 min)

- Quick Tribal Council vote on 3 tough questions from the simulation
- Award **Ocean Survival Badges** 🌊
- Journey Map: Ocean = CONQUERED
- "Tomorrow we reach the SUMMIT. One more terrain. You've got this."

⛰️ FRIDAY — The Summit

Theme: “You’ve crossed every terrain. Today you reach the summit. Look how far you’ve come. You’re ready.”

Focus: Test strategies, confidence, celebration

Trail Briefing (10 min)

Teacher Script: > “Explorers. Look at your journey map. Jungle — conquered. Desert — conquered. Mountains — conquered. Ocean — conquered. Today, you reach the SUMMIT. The summit isn’t about learning new things. It’s about standing at the top and seeing everything clearly. Today we review our strategies, celebrate our journey, and prepare for the STAAR. You are SURVIVORS. You are ready.”

Survival Training 1 (45 min)

1. **(15 min) “Survival Guide Review”** — Review top 10 test-taking strategies framed as survival rules: “Rule #1: Never eat unknown berries = Never pick an answer you can’t prove with evidence.”
2. **(15 min) “Campfire Stories”** — Teacher reads test-taking strategies as adventure tales. “Once, an explorer was lost in a reading passage. She couldn’t find the main idea. But then she remembered: look at the first and last paragraph. The trail markers were there all along…”
3. **(15 min) “Final Challenge” Fun Review Game** — Quick, light-stakes game. Celebrate right answers loudly.

Rest Stop (5 min)

- Quiet meditation: “Close your eyes. You’re standing on the summit. Feel the wind. You made it.”

Survival Training 2 (40 min)

1. **(10 min) “Letters from the Summit”** — Students write a letter to themselves from the top of the mountain
2. **(10 min) “Survival Certificate” Ceremony** — Award certificates to each explorer. Make it meaningful.

3. **(10 min) "Summit Photo"** — Class photo, students sign each other's Explorer Journals
4. **(10 min) Celebration** — Treats, music, joy. "You survived STAAR-vival!"

Final Tribal Council

- Award **Summit Survival Badges** ⛰️
- All 5 badges = "Ultimate Survivor" status
- Journey Map: ALL TERRAINS CONQUERED 🎉
- Final class cheer: "We SURVIVED! We're STAAR READY!"

🎵 Daily Playlist / Ambiance

Day	Ambiance
Monday	Jungle sounds (birds, rain) + adventure movie scores
Tuesday	Desert wind sounds + Arabian-style instrumental
Wednesday	Mountain wind + epic orchestral
Thursday	Ocean waves + calm instrumental
Friday	Triumphant music — "Eye of the Tiger," "We Are the Champions," celebration hits

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Every terrain conquered. Every skill sharpened. You're summit-ready. ⛰️

🌿 STAAR-vival — Themed Activities

> *12 survival-themed activities. Includes the legendary Tribal Council game.*

🎮 REVIEW GAMES

1. Tribal Council (End-of-Day Review Game)

Type: Whole class teams | **Time:** 10-15 min | **Best for:** Daily review (any subject)

Setup: - Divide class into 3-4 "tribes" (table groups) - Teacher is the "Council Leader"

How to Play: 1. Teacher reads a STAAR-format question aloud 2. Tribes huddle and discuss (60 seconds) 3. Each tribe holds up their answer (A/B/C/D card) 4. Correct tribes "survive." Wrong tribes get a "strike" 5. 3 strikes = tribe is "voted off the island" (they still play but can't win the final prize) 6. Last tribe standing wins daily Tribal Council

Variations: - **Immunity Challenge:** One question where tribes can wager their strikes — get it right, remove a strike. Get it wrong, add one. - **Hidden Immunity Idol:** One random question is a "gimme" — all tribes that attempt it get a strike removed - **Merge:** On Friday, dissolve tribes. It's every explorer for themselves.

Materials: A/B/C/D cards (one set per tribe), questions, scoreboard for strikes

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2. Wilderness Escape Room

Type: Small groups (3-4) | **Time:** 30-40 min | **Best for:** Mixed subject review

Setup: - 5 "terrain locks" (envelopes), each with 4-5 questions - Correct answers generate a code - Final code unlocks the "escape from the wilderness" (prize envelope)

How to Play: 1. Groups work through Lock 1 (Jungle) → Lock 2 (Desert) → Lock 3 (Mountain) → Lock 4 (Ocean) → Lock 5 (Summit) 2. Must solve all questions correctly to get each code 3. Bring code to teacher to verify before moving to next lock 4. First group to crack all 5 and "escape" wins 5. All groups that finish earn "Escape Expert" badges

Materials: 5 envelopes per group, question sets, code answer key, prize envelope

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3. Predator vs. Prey (Speed Review)

Type: Class game | **Time:** 15 min | **Best for:** Vocabulary, facts, computation

Setup: - Two students stand (Predator and Prey) - Teacher asks a question - First to answer correctly “survives” and stays standing - Loser sits, next person stands as the new challenger

How to Play: 1. Predator and Prey face each other 2. Teacher asks a question 3. First correct answer = that student is the Predator (stays) 4. Loser becomes Prey and sits, next person in line stands 5. Whoever has the longest “survival streak” wins

Materials: Question list, optional bell/buzzer

👤 INDIVIDUAL ACTIVITIES

4. Explorer Journal (Daily Reflection)

Type: Individual | **Time:** 10-15 min | **Best for:** Writing practice, metacognition

Instructions: Daily journal entries in their Explorer Journal (a booklet or stapled pages): - **Monday (Jungle):** “Today I navigated through… The thickest part was… I found my way by…” - **Tuesday (Desert):** “Resources are scarce. The math skill I need to conserve/strengthen is… My plan…” - **Wednesday (Mountains):** “The steepest climb was… I conquered it by…” - **Thursday (Ocean):** “The current pulled me toward… I stayed on course by…” - **Friday (Summit):** “From the summit I can see everything I’ve learned… My advice to future explorers…”

Materials: Explorer Journal booklet (5 pages + cover), pencils

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5. Survival Guide Creation (Study Tool)

Type: Individual | **Time:** 25 min | **Best for:** End-of-topic synthesis

Instructions: Students create a pocket-sized “Survival Guide” — a folded booklet with essential knowledge organized by terrain: - **Jungle Section (Reading):** Top 3 reading strategies - **Desert Section (Math):** Key formulas and steps - **Mountain Section (Science/SS):** Must-know facts - **Ocean Section (Mixed):** Common mistakes to avoid - **Summit Section (Strategies):** Test-day game plan

Fold a single sheet of paper into an 8-page mini-book (search “one-page book fold” for instructions).

Materials: 1 sheet of paper per student, scissors, pencils/markers

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6. Terrain Mapping (Concept Web)

Type: Individual | **Time:** 15-20 min | **Best for:** Organizing knowledge visually

Instructions: Students draw a map with 5 terrain zones. In each zone, they place key concepts for that day’s subject: - Draw terrain features (trees for jungle, cacti for desert, etc.) - Write concepts as “landmarks” within each terrain - Draw paths connecting related concepts across terrains - Add a “You Are Here” marker for their current confidence level

Materials: Large paper, colored pencils/markers

👥 PARTNER ACTIVITIES

7. Buddy System Navigation (Partner Problem Solving)

Type: Partner | **Time:** 20 min | **Best for:** Math, multi-step reading questions

Instructions: - Partners are “trail buddies” — they must stay together (agree on each answer before moving forward) - Work through a set of 8 problems - For each problem: discuss strategy FIRST (1 min), then solve together - Both partners must be able to explain the answer — teacher randomly checks - “In the wilderness, you never leave your buddy behind!”

Materials: Problem set, paper, pencils

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8. SOS Signal (Partner Quiz Creation)

Type: Partner | **Time:** 20 min | **Best for:** Any subject review

Instructions: Each pair creates an “SOS Signal” — a set of 5 questions about their weakest topics (things they need to be “rescued” from). Then they swap with another pair

and answer each other's SOS signals. If they can answer another pair's SOS, they've "rescued" them!

Materials: Paper, pencils

👥👥 GROUP ACTIVITIES

9. Base Camp Stations (Rotation)

Type: Groups of 4-5 | **Time:** 30-35 min | **Best for:** Multi-topic review

Setup: 5 stations, each themed as a terrain: - 🌴 **Jungle Station** — Reading comprehension questions - 🏜️ **Desert Station** — Math computation and word problems - ⛰️ **Mountain Station** — Science review - 🌊 **Ocean Station** — Social studies / mixed review - ⛰️ **Summit Station** — Test-taking strategy scenarios ("What would you do if…?")

Groups rotate every 6 minutes. Record answers on an expedition log sheet.

Materials: Station question sets, expedition log sheets, timer, terrain labels

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10. Campfire Stories (Read-Aloud Strategy Tales)

Type: Whole class or small groups | **Time:** 15-20 min | **Best for:** Test strategy review (Friday)

Instructions: Teacher (or student volunteers) reads test-taking strategies as short adventure tales:

Example: *"Once, deep in the jungle of a reading passage, Explorer Maria was lost. The question asked for the 'main idea,' but every paragraph seemed to say something different. She was about to panic — but then she remembered her training. 'Check the first sentence of each paragraph,' her trail guide had taught her. She went back. She read each opening sentence. And there it was — a common thread running through every paragraph. The main idea emerged from the jungle like a clearing in the trees. Maria marked her answer with confidence and moved on."*

Write 5 of these (one per strategy). Students LOVE this format — it makes strategies memorable.

Materials: Pre-written strategy stories (teacher creates or adapts)

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11. Survival Challenge Relay

Type: Teams of 5-6 | **Time:** 15-20 min | **Best for:** Quick review, computation, vocabulary

Instructions: Each team is a "survival crew." Line up relay-style. 1. First explorer runs to the front, grabs a "supply" (question card), answers it 2. Correct = bring the supply back to base camp. Wrong = put it back, next person tries 3. Team must collect all 6 supplies (answer all 6 questions) to "survive" 4. First team to collect all supplies wins

Materials: Question cards in envelopes, answer key

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12. Expedition Map (Collaborative Poster)

Type: Groups of 3-4 | **Time:** 25-30 min | **Best for:** Synthesis, study guide creation

Instructions: Each group creates a large illustrated "expedition map" for one subject/topic: - Draw a path from "Start" to "Summit" - Along the path, add key concepts as landmarks - Add "Danger Zones" (common mistakes) with warning signs - Add "Safe Havens" (helpful strategies) with shelter icons - Add "Treasure" (bonus tips) hidden along the route

Post all maps on the wall — they become collaborative study guides.

Materials: Butcher paper or poster board, markers, textbooks/notes

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📝 Activity Planning Matrix

Activity	Best Day	Duration	Type	Subject
Tribal Council	Daily	10-15 min	Team game	Any
Wilderness Escape Room	Thu or Fri	30-40 min	Group game	Mixed
Predator vs. Prey	Any (warm-up)	15 min	Class game	Quick recall
Explorer Journal	Daily	10-15 min	Individual	Writing
Survival Guide	Wed or Fri	25 min	Individual	All subjects
Terrain Mapping	Mon or Wed	15-20 min	Individual	Any
Buddy System Navigation	Tue	20 min	Partner	Math
SOS Signal	Wed or Thu	20 min	Partner	Weak areas
Base Camp Stations	Wed	30-35 min	Group rotation	Mixed
Campfire Stories	Fri	15-20 min	Class read-aloud	Strategies
Survival Challenge Relay	Tue or Fri	15-20 min	Team relay	Quick review
Expedition Map	Thu	25-30 min	Group project	Synthesis

Survive every terrain. Conquer every challenge. Reach the summit. ⛰️

🌿 STAAR-vival — Student Materials

> *Every student-facing material for the survival journey.*

📋 Daily Materials Overview

Day	Handouts	Rewards
Monday	Explorer Journal, Badge Card, Survival Kit, Jungle Challenge Packet	Jungle Badge 🌴
Tuesday	Desert Challenge Packet, Terrain Map activity	Desert Badge 🏜️
Wednesday	Mountain Challenge Packet, Compass Rose activity	Mountain Badge ⛰️ + treat
Thursday	Ocean Deep Dive Simulation, Self-Assessment	Ocean Badge 🌊
Friday	Summit Strategy Sheet, Letter from Summit, Yearbook page	Summit Badge ⛰️ + Certificate

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📓 Explorer Journal (Week-Long Booklet)

Description: A 5-page booklet (plus cover) that students write in daily. Their expedition diary.

Cover: - Title: “EXPLORER JOURNAL” - Subtitle: “The Official Field Notes of Explorer [Name]” - “Expedition: STAAR-vival [Year]” - “Team: [Table Group Terrain Name]” - Illustration space: student draws themselves as an explorer

Inside pages (one per day): - Header: “Day [#] — [Terrain Name] — [Date]” - Small terrain illustration in corner - Daily prompt (see LESSON-PLANS.md for specific prompts) - 12-15 lined writing spaces - “Survival Tip of the Day:” (blank — teacher writes one, students copy) - Footer: “Explorer signature: _____”

Assembly: Print double-sided, fold and staple. Or print single pages and have students keep in a folder.

🗺️ Survival Badge Card

Description: A card with 5 terrain-shaped badge slots. Students earn one badge per day.

Design: - Size: 5” x 7” (print 2 per page) - Title: “STAAR-VIVAL BADGE TRACKER” - 5 badge slots arranged as a winding trail: 1. 🌴 **Jungle** (leaf shape) 2. 🏜️ **Desert** (cactus shape) 3. ⛰️ **Mountain** (triangle/peak shape) 4. 🌊 **Ocean** (wave shape) 5. ⛰️ **Summit** (flag shape) - Dotted trail connecting all 5 - “Survive all 5 terrains to become an ULTIMATE SURVIVOR” - Student name at top

Badge options: Sticker in each slot, teacher stamp, or drawn checkmark.

📝 Daily Challenge Packets

Format: - **Cover:** “TERRAIN: [Name] — SURVIVAL CHALLENGE” - Terrain illustration - “Explorer: _____ Team: _____ Date: _____” - “Objective:” themed description - “Difficulty: 🔥 🔥 🔥 ” (fire icons for difficulty level) - **Content:** STAAR-format questions (teacher provides) - **Back page:** “Field Notes” — 3 reflection questions: 1. “Terrain conquered! My strongest skill today:” 2. “Biggest obstacle I faced:” 3. “My survival strategy for tomorrow:”

🗺️ Journey Map (Student Version)

Description: A personal, smaller version of the classroom journey map. Students track their own progress.

Design: - 8.5x11 landscape - Illustrated path through 5 terrains (Jungle → Desert → Mountains → Ocean → Summit) - Each terrain has a checkbox: “□ Survived!” - Small facts/tips written along the path as “trail markers” - “START” at bottom left, “SUMMIT” at top right - Space to color in each terrain as it’s completed

Students color in each section as they complete it. By Friday, the whole map is colored = “EXPEDITION COMPLETE.”

🧭 Compass Rose Activity

Description: Wednesday activity — students create a compass rose organizing their knowledge by subject.

Template: - Large compass rose taking up most of the page - N = Reading/ELA, E = Math, S = Science, W = Social Studies - Along each direction: 3-4 blank lines for students to write key concepts - Center circle: “NAVIGATE YOUR LEARNING” - Decorative border with terrain elements

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📖 Survival Guide (Mini-Book)

Description: A one-page fold into an 8-page mini-booklet. Students create their own study guide organized by terrain.

Pages: 1. Cover: “Survival Guide — Explorer [Name]” 2. Jungle (Reading): Top strategies 3. Desert (Math): Key formulas/steps 4. Mountain (Science): Must-know facts 5. Ocean (Social Studies): Key events/concepts 6. Summit (Test Strategies): Game-day plan 7. “Emergency Procedures” (what to do when stuck) 8. Back cover: “I SURVIVED STAAR-VIVAL!”

🏆 Survival Certificate

Design: - 8.5x11 landscape - Title: “ULTIMATE SURVIVOR CERTIFICATE” - Body: “This certifies that **Explorer [Name]** has survived all five terrains of the STAAR-vival Expedition — Jungle, Desert, Mountains, Ocean, and Summit — and has earned the rank of **ULTIMATE SURVIVOR**. This explorer is cleared for STAAR and ready to conquer any challenge.” - Signature: “Lead Explorer [Teacher Name]” - Border: terrain elements (leaves, cacti, mountains, waves) - Seal: compass rose graphic

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📦 Survival Kit (Monday Handout)

Description: A ziplock bag with essential "supplies" — doubles as a fun first-day surprise.

Contents: - 2 sharpened pencils ("fire starters") - 1 eraser ("first aid") - 1 small snack — granola bar, fruit snack, etc. ("rations") - 1 small note: "Explorer — you have everything you need to survive this week. Use your tools wisely!"

Label on bag: "STAAR-VIVAL KIT — Explorer [Name]"

Cost: ~$0.25-0.50 per student if buying in bulk. Optional — pencils and erasers alone work fine.

✉️ Letter from the Summit (Friday)

Template: - Header: "FROM THE SUMMIT OF STAAR MOUNTAIN" - "Dear Future Me," - "I survived the jungle of reading by..." - "I crossed the desert of math by..." - "I climbed the mountain of science/social studies by..." - "On STAAR day, I will remember..." - "I am an Ultimate Survivor because..." - "See you at the top! — Explorer [Name]"

Students seal in envelopes. Teacher returns on STAAR test day.

📊 Printing Summary

Material	Per Student	For 25 Students
Explorer Journal (booklet)	3 pages (double-sided)	75 pages
Badge Card	0.5 pages	13 pages
Challenge Packets (5 days)	~3-5/day	75-125 pages
Journey Map	1 page	25 pages

Material	Per Student	For 25 Students
Compass Rose	1 page	25 pages
Survival Guide (mini-book)	1 page	25 pages
Certificate	1 page	25 pages
Letter template	1 page	25 pages
TOTAL (ex. packets)		**~215 pages + packets**

Equip your explorers. They'll treasure these materials long after the expedition ends. 🌿

🌿 STAAR-vival — Decoration Guide

> *Transform your space into a wilderness expedition route.*

🕐 Setup Timeline

When	What
2 weeks before	Buy supplies, start cutting vines/leaves
1 week before	Prepare door signs, floor tracks
Friday before	Hallway setup (2 hours with help)
Monday morning	Classroom final touches (30 min)

🌴 HALLWAY: Wilderness Trail

The Vision

The hallway becomes a trail through different terrains. Jungle vines hang from above, animal tracks on the floor lead to classrooms, and each door is a different "base camp."

Step-by-Step

1. Jungle Vines

- Twist **green crepe paper streamers** into vine shapes. Hang from ceiling/top of walls
- Add paper **leaves** cut from green construction paper (various shades)
- Twist brown paper bags into "tree branches" and tape to walls near doorframes
- **Cost:** ~$4-6 for streamers + construction paper

2. Animal Tracks on the Floor

- Cut **animal footprints** from brown/black construction paper (paw prints, bird tracks, boot prints)
- Tape to the floor creating a trail from the hallway entrance to each classroom
- Or use painter's tape to make simple track shapes
- **Cost:** ~$2-3 for paper, $2 for tape

3. Base Camp Door Signs

- Each classroom door = a different base camp
- **"Base Camp [Teacher Name] — [Terrain]: [Subject]"**
- Example: "Base Camp Rodriguez — Desert Terrain: Mathematics"
- Print on brown cardstock (looks like parchment/wood)
- Add terrain-appropriate graphics (cacti, trees, waves, mountains)
- **Cost:** ~$2 for cardstock

4. Main Entrance Sign

- Large banner: **"STAAR-VIVAL: THE EXPEDITION BEGINS HERE"**

- Use brown butcher paper for a “wooden sign” look
- Write with thick black marker
- Add paper leaves and vines around the edges
- **Cost:** ~$0-2

5. Terrain Zone Markers

- Along the hallway, post signs marking different “zones”:
  - “⚠️ ENTERING JUNGLE ZONE — Watch for snakes!”
  - “🏜️ DESERT AHEAD — Conserve your water!”
  - “⛰️ MOUNTAIN PASS — Steep climb ahead!”
- Adds immersion as students walk to class
- **Cost:** ~$1 for paper

Hallway Materials & Budget

Item	Qty	Source	Cost
Green crepe paper/streamers	4-6 rolls	Dollar Tree	$4-6
Construction paper (green, brown, black)	2-3 packs	Dollar Tree	$2-3
Brown cardstock or paper bags	10-15 sheets/bags	Dollar Tree/school	$1-2
Painter’s tape	1-2 rolls	Dollar Tree	$2-3
Brown butcher paper	1 section	School supply	$0
TOTAL			**$9-14**

🏕️ CLASSROOM: Base Camp

Door Sign

- **"BASE CAMP [Room #] — EXPLORERS ONLY"**
- Brown cardstock, hand-drawn compass rose, rugged font style
- Optional: add a paper "tent flap" (construction paper folded) framing the door window

Desk Setup

- Desks in clusters = "expedition teams"
- Each team has a terrain name: Team Jungle, Team Desert, Team Mountain, Team Ocean
- Desk name tags: **"Explorer [Name] — Team [Terrain]"** on brown/kraft paper
- Place a **Survival Kit** (ziplock bag with 2 pencils, eraser, small treat) at each desk on Monday

Wall Decorations

Journey Map (CENTERPIECE)

- Large poster or butcher paper map showing 5 terrains in order: Jungle → Desert → Mountains → Ocean → Summit
- Draw a winding path through all 5
- Add a moveable marker (sticky note, pin, magnet) showing current position
- Student names listed; add stickers as they complete each terrain
- **This is the most important decoration.** Make it big and visible.

Compass Rose

- Large compass rose on the wall (N/S/E/W)
- Each direction = a subject: N=Reading, S=Math, E=Science, W=Social Studies
- Center: "Navigate Your Learning"

Motivational Posters

- "The only way out is THROUGH." 🌿

- “Survivors don’t quit. They adapt.”
- “Every expert explorer was once lost.”
- “The summit is closer than you think.”
- “Leave no question unanswered. Leave no explorer behind.”

Supply Station

- Corner of the room labeled “SUPPLY DEPOT”
- Organize pencils, erasers, scratch paper in labeled containers
- Use camping-style labels: “Fire Starters” (pencils), “First Aid” (erasers), “Rations” (snacks if applicable)

Classroom Materials

Item	Qty	Source	Cost
Door sign	1	Printed on brown cardstock	$0-1
Desk name tags	1 per student	Brown/kraft paper	$0-2
Journey Map poster	1 large	Butcher paper	$0-2
Compass rose	1	Poster board	$1
Motivational posters	4-5	Printed	$0
Survival kits	1 per student	Ziplock + pencils + eraser	$5-10
Supply station labels	4-5	Paper + marker	$0
TOTAL			**$6-16**

🖨️ Printable Elements Needed

Printable	Description	Size
Door Sign	“Base Camp — Explorers Only” with compass, rugged style	11x17
Base Camp Hallway Signs	One per classroom, terrain-themed	8.5x11
Entrance Banner	“STAAR-VIVAL: The Expedition Begins Here”	Banner
Animal Track Cutouts	Various animal prints for floor trail	3-4 inches
Terrain Zone Signs	Warning-style signs for hallway zones	8.5x11
Explorer Desk Tags	“Explorer [Name] — Team [Terrain]” on kraft/brown style	Tent fold
Journey Map	Large illustrated map with 5 terrains and path (teacher completes)	24x36
Compass Rose	4-direction compass with subject labels	18x18
Survival Badge Cards	5 badge slots shaped as terrain icons (tree, cactus, mountain, wave, flag)	5x7
Survival Certificate	“This certifies [Name] has survived all 5 terrains…”	8.5x11 landscape
Motivational Posters	4-5 adventure-themed quotes	8.5x11
Leaf Cutouts	Various green leaf shapes for vine decoration	3-5 inches

💰 Total Budget

Area	Low	High
Hallway	$9	$14

Area	Low	High
Classroom	$6	$16
Printing	$0	$8
TOTAL	**$15**	**$38**

Dollar Store List

- ☐ Green streamers x4 ($4)
- ☐ Construction paper (green/brown) x2 ($2)
- ☐ Painter's tape ($1)
- ☐ Poster board x2 ($2)
- ☐ Ziplock bags ($1)
- ☐ Small treats/candy ($2-3)
- **Total: ~$12-13**

Nature doesn't have to be perfect. Crumpled paper vines and hand-drawn leaves create MORE atmosphere than polished decorations. Embrace the wild! 🌿

🌿 STAAR-vival — Parent Letter

English Version

[School Letterhead]

[Date]

Dear Families,

Next week, our classroom is going on an adventure! We're launching **STAAR-vival** — a survival/adventure-themed STAAR prep week where your child will journey through five

“terrains” (Jungle, Desert, Mountains, Ocean, and Summit) while reviewing key skills for the upcoming STAAR test. 🌿⛰️

What is STAAR-vival? It’s a fun, immersive review week. Each day focuses on a different terrain (subject area), with themed activities, challenges, and team-based learning. Students earn “Survival Badges” for each terrain they conquer, and by Friday, they’ll be certified “Ultimate Survivors” — confident and ready for STAAR.

When: [Monday, Date] – [Friday, Date]

What your child will experience: - 🗺️ Daily survival challenges reviewing [Reading/Math/Science/Social Studies] - 🌴 A classroom and hallway transformed into a wilderness expedition - 📓 An Explorer Journal for daily reflections - 🏆 Survival badges, team challenges, and a Friday celebration

How to support your explorer at home: 1. **Plenty of sleep** — Explorers need rest for the journey! 8-10 hours nightly 2. **Ask about their terrain** — “What terrain did you survive today?” keeps the adventure alive 3. **Encourage review** — Your child may bring home a pocket “Survival Guide” — flip through it together 4. **Stay positive** — “You’ve been training all year. You’re ready for any terrain!” 5. **Healthy meals** — Brain fuel for the expedition

Thank you for supporting your child’s adventure! Please reach out with any questions.

Happy trails! ⛰️

[Teacher Name] [Contact info]

Versión en Español

[Membrete de la escuela]

[Fecha]

Estimadas familias,

¡La próxima semana, nuestro salón se va de aventura! Estamos lanzando **STAAR-vival** — una semana de preparación para el STAAR con tema de supervivencia y aventura, donde

su hijo(a) viajará a través de cinco “terrenos” (Selva, Desierto, Montañas, Océano y Cumbre) mientras repasa habilidades clave para el examen STAAR. 🌿⛰️

¿Qué es STAAR-vival? Es una semana de repaso divertida e inmersiva. Cada día se enfoca en un terreno diferente (área de estudio), con actividades temáticas, desafíos y aprendizaje en equipo. Los estudiantes ganan “Insignias de Supervivencia” por cada terreno conquistado.

Cuándo: [Lunes, fecha] – [Viernes, fecha]

Cómo apoyar a su explorador(a) en casa: 1. **Suficiente descanso** — 8-10 horas cada noche 2. **Pregunte sobre su terreno** — “¿Qué terreno sobreviviste hoy?” 3. **Fomente el repaso** — Su hijo(a) puede traer una “Guía de Supervivencia” a casa 4. **Sea positivo(a)** — “¡Has entrenado todo el año. Estás listo(a)!” 5. **Buena alimentación** — Combustible para la expedición

¡Felices senderos! ⛰️

[Nombre del maestro(a)] [Información de contacto]

Customize all [ ] fields before sending.